

*Illustration by* SIDDHANT JUMDE

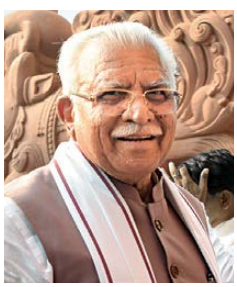
GLASSHOUSE

## SAVE THE DATE

Vice-president **Jagdeep Dhankhar** has never set great store by protocol. So it was during a recent trip to Guwahati, when he chose to touch the feet of Assam governor Gulab Chand Kataria on stage at an educational institution. Though the 72-year-old vice-president occupies a higher office, he is seven years younger than the Assam governor in terms of age. Both Dhankhar and Kataria also hail from Rajasthan. The vice-prsident, in fact, was on a roll. While making a speech, he said he would never forget the birthday of Assam chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma (February 1), for it was a tragic day in his life. The explanation came a significant pause later—he got married on the date. Wonder if Mrs Dhankhar shares the vice-president's sense of humour.

## Command Centre

In a surprise reshuffle, Haryana BJP chief Om Prakash Dhankar, a known rival of Chief Minister **Manohar Lal Khattar**, has been shifted to the national team. Khattar loyalist and Kurukshetra MP Nayab S. Saini takes his place. Saini is not a Jat like his predecessor and it seems the party, for now, is backing Khattar's 'non-Jat politics' idea in the state. This is unlikely to go down well with ally, the Jat-dominated Jannayak Janata Party. But with Khattar calling the shots, is there anything they can do?



## WHAT'S IN A NAME?





A suggestion to rename Ramanagara, the picturesque district south of Bengaluru where *Sholay* was shot in the 1970s, has led to a face-off between the region's two political heavyweights, **D.K. Shivakumar** and **H.D. Kumaraswamy**. DKS, citing the local population's emotional bond with the capital, wants to rename it Bengaluru South. Kumaraswamy, who as CM in 2007, had carved out Ramanagara from the larger Bengaluru Rural district, has threatened to go on a fast unto death. Even Gabbar might not be able to solve this one.



## Ghosh and *josh*

Former Bengal BJP chief **Dilip Ghosh**'s acolytes are just not ready to accept his shrinking role in the organisation. He has been removed from all party posts and reduced to mere MP status of late. He got a boost, though, on October 30 when he visited the party office in Kolkata for a post-Durga Puja celebration. Many of those present raised slogans asking, "How is the josh?...Dilip Ghosh." The cadre's enthusiasm for his predecessor will not go down well with current state unit chief Sukanta Majumdar. As for the ruling Trinamool Congress, it's with glee that they talk of the "faction-ridden" BJP in Bengal.

## A BATTLE FOR LOST GROUND

Is Lalu Prasad's elder son and Bihar minister **Tej Pratap Yadav** readying himself to take on Rajiv Pratap Rudy, the BJP MP from Saran? A Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) bastion in the past—it elected Lalu four times—the constituency has been Rudy's happy hunting ground for the past two elections. The four-time MP defeated RJD candidates Rabri Devi (Lalu's wife) in 2014 and Tej's father-in-law (now estranged) Chandrika Rai in 2019. On October 25, Lalu visited Saran after six years while Tej was in the district four days later for a programme where he even played the flute. RJD sources say Rudy will have to "face the music", come 2024.



**Kaushik Deka with Anilesh S. Mahajan, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Amitabh Srivastava and Ajay Sukumaran**